



Core Gameplay Loop for Inner Alignment

A Somatic IFS Approach

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Agency School

April 12, 2026

Link to slides:



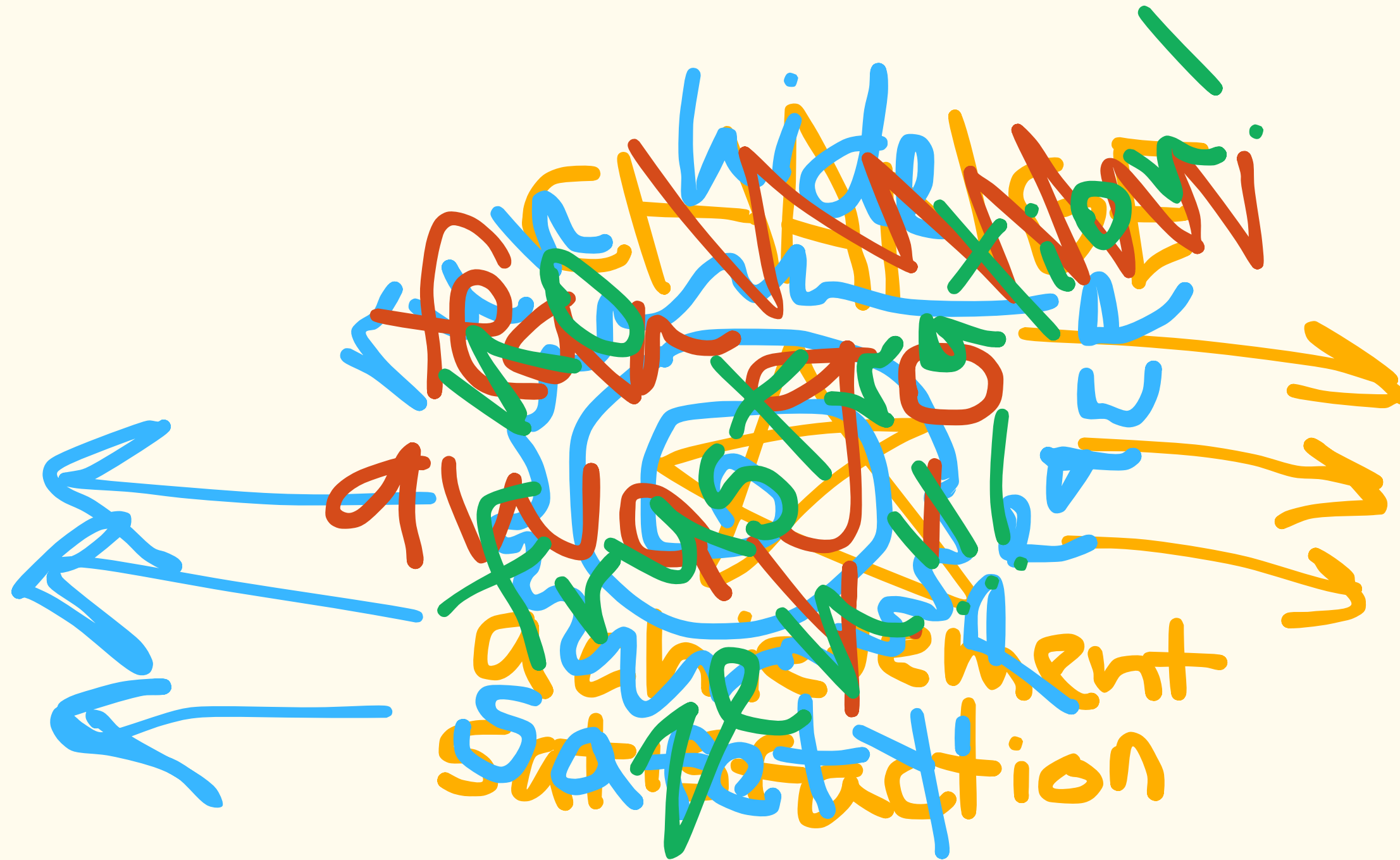
I'll also tweet them
@SarahAMcManus



Drawing from:
Internal Family Systems
Coherence Therapy
Core Transformation
“Feeding Your Demons”
Somatic practices

Agency and inner conflict

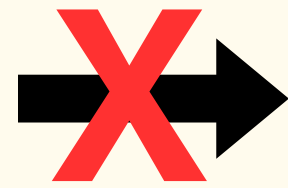
It's hard to “just do things” when your wants look like this...



Working with inner conflict

From tangles and tug-of-war to coherent flow

More effective actions



Wider possibility space for congruent actions

Outline

1. Untangling & turning towards

Questions

2. Wants / needs / feelings

Questions

Troubleshooting

Reflections

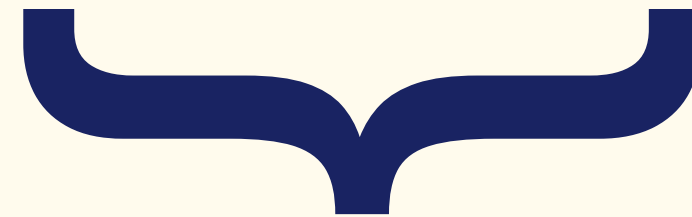
Working with inner conflict

Grounding

Staying with your experience

Tracking

Understanding and differentiating



Attuned presence

Spacious connection that invites unfolding and clarity

self-accompaniment

coherence empathy

curiosity

Resonating Self-Witness

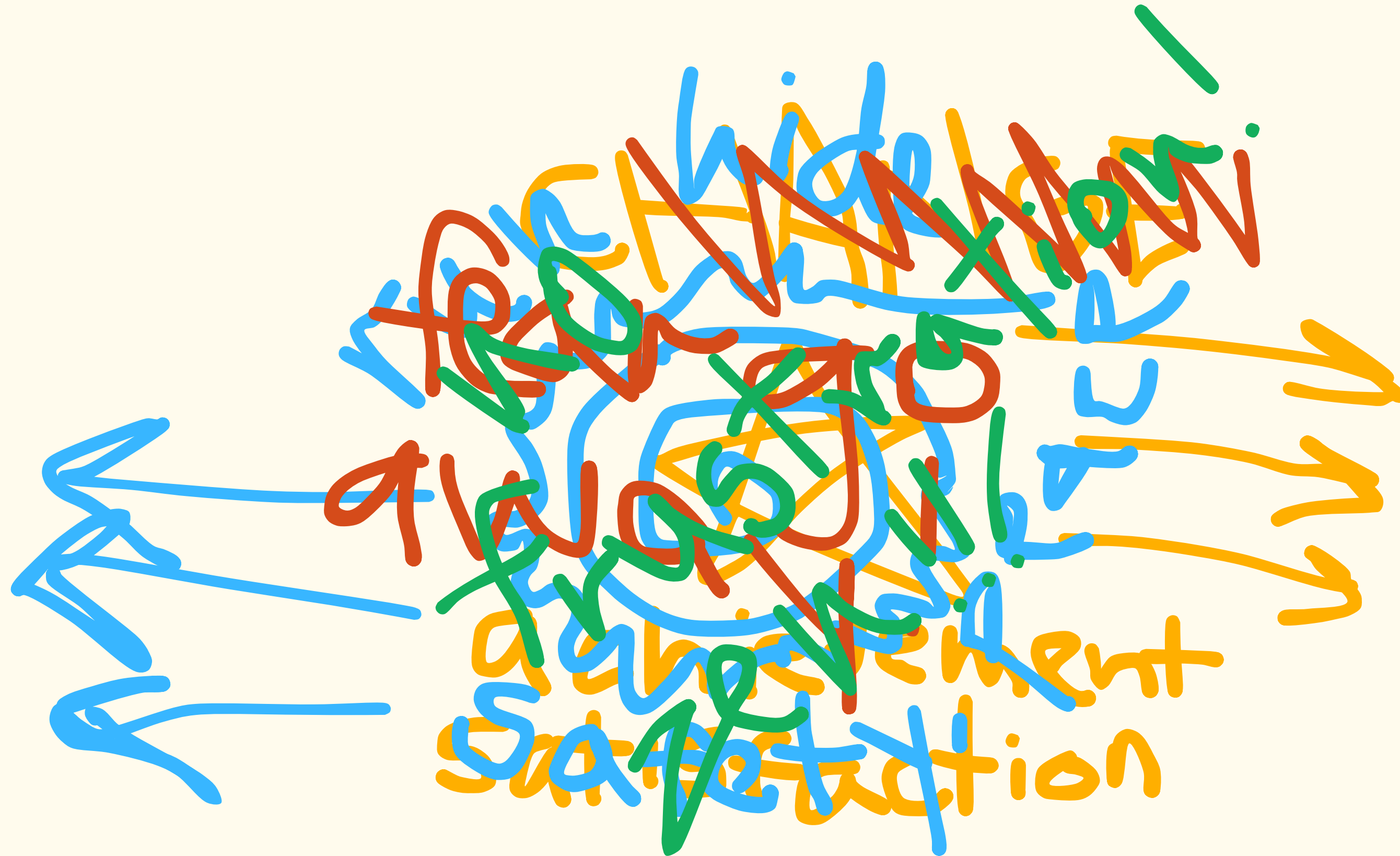
connection

compassion

calm

Untangling

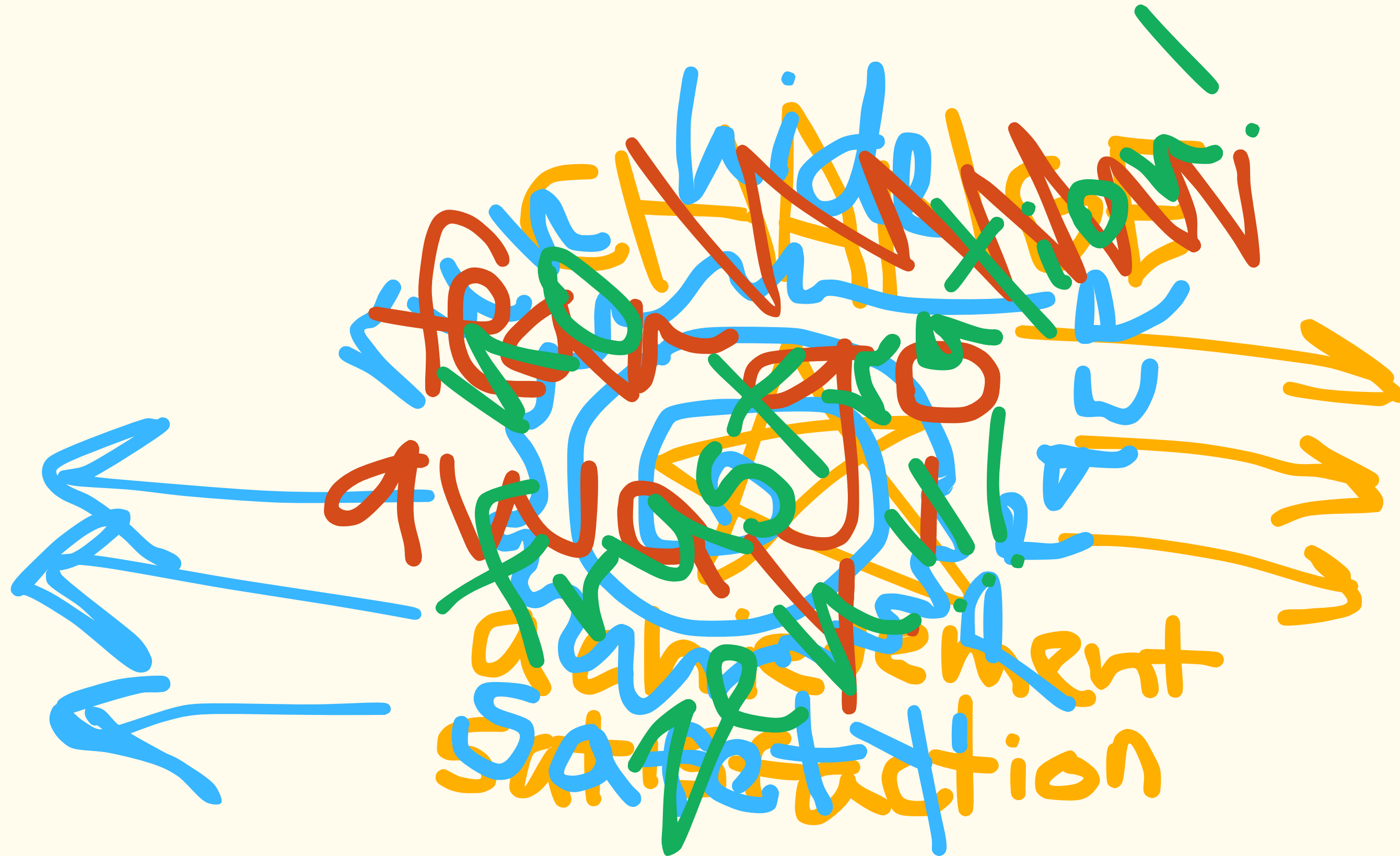
Notice what's arising



Thoughts, emotions, images, memories, body sensations, etc.

Untangling

What needs your attention first?



Untangling

Notice the qualities of body sensations

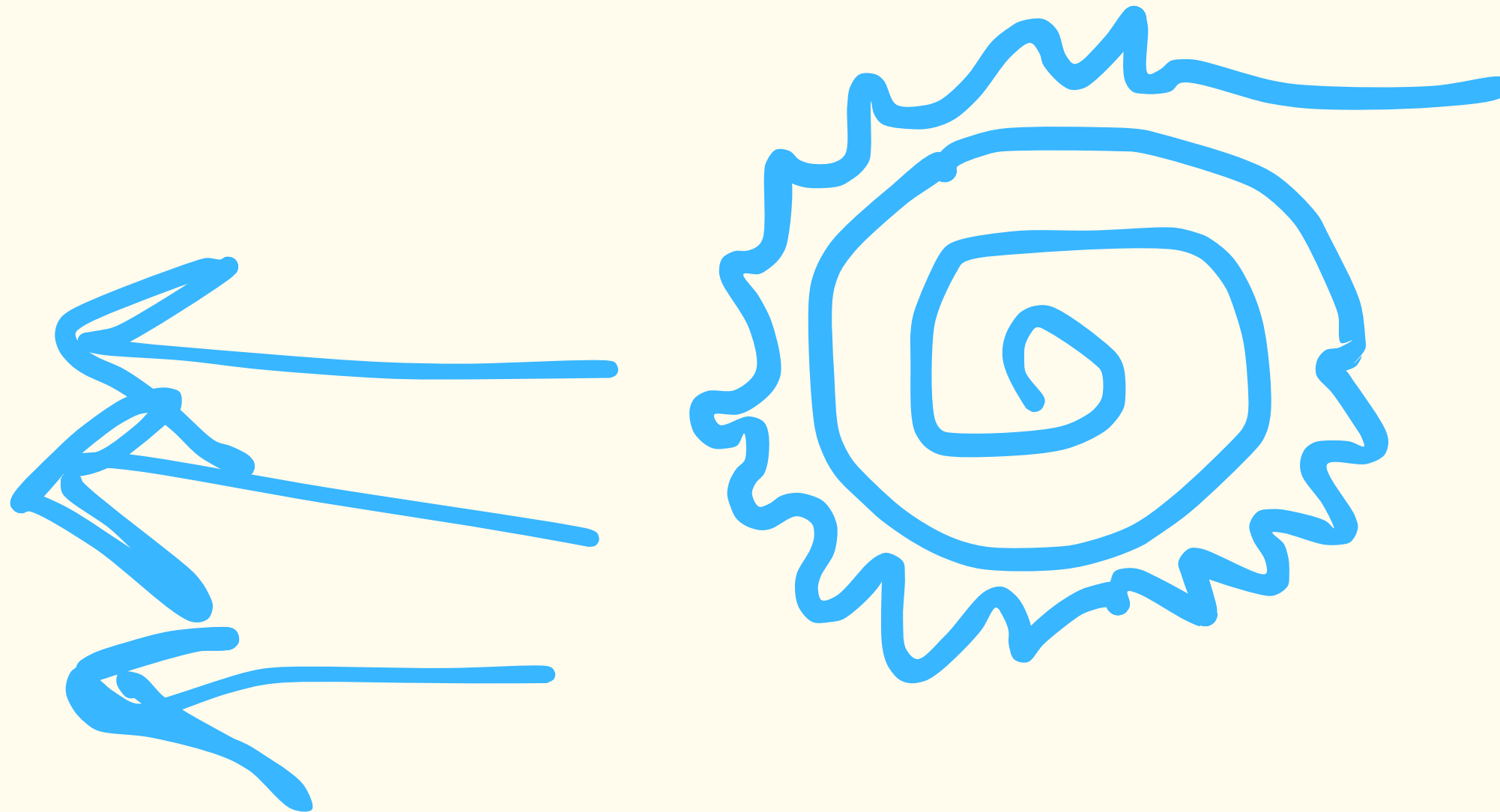
If it had a temperature, would it be warm, or cool?

If it had a color, a texture, a motion, what's that like?

Any other imagery?

What's its deal?

What might you call it?



FEAR

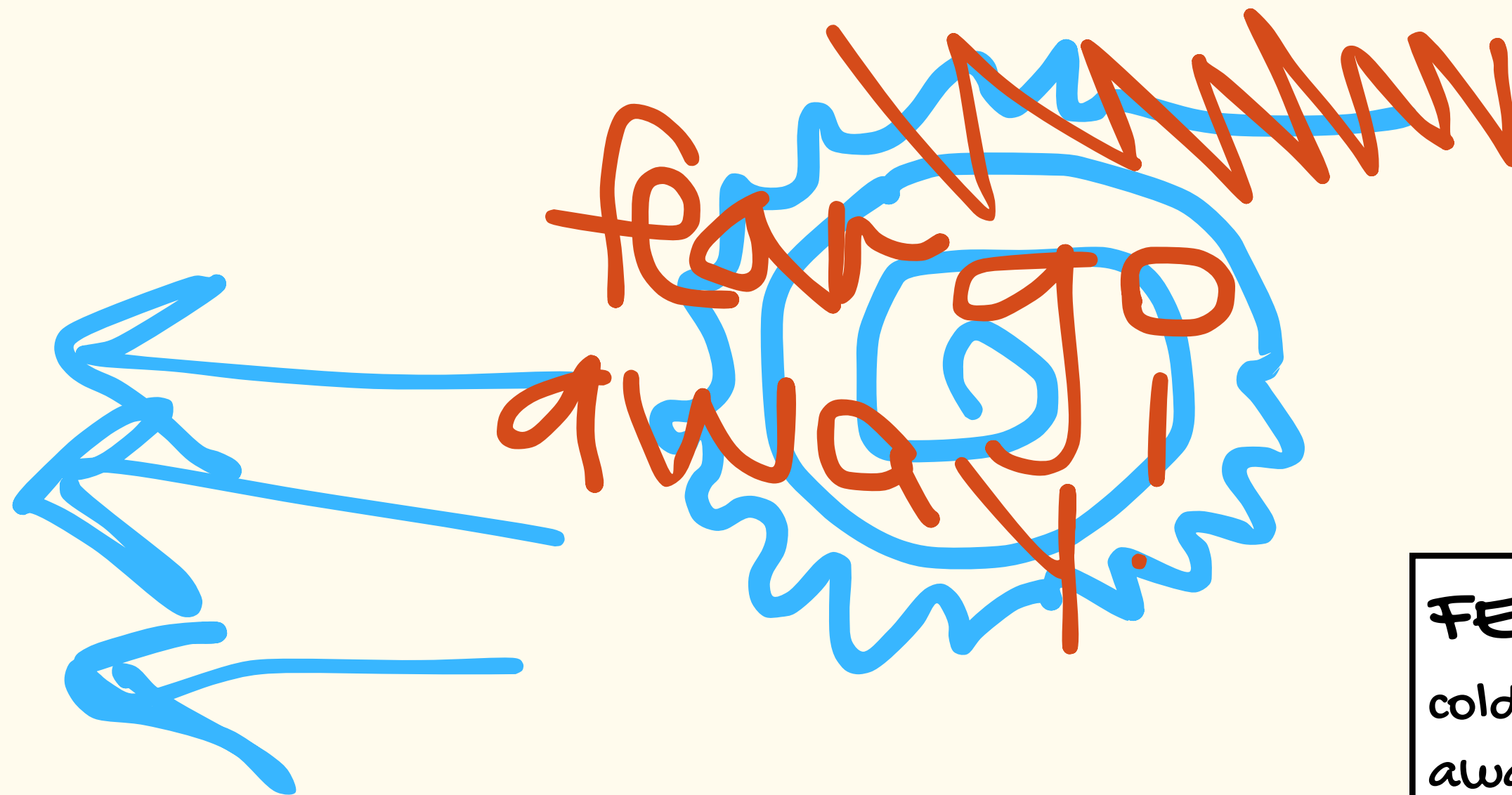
cold heavy tight, in chest
awayness

Untangling

How do you feel towards **that**?

Curiosity, compassion, calm?

or....



FEAR

cold heavy tight, in chest
awayness

Untangling

How do you feel towards **that**?

For this **new layer**, notice the qualities of body sensations, imagery, what's its deal...



FRUSTRATED

grimace, gmr
want fear to GO AWAY

FE

col

aw

Untangling

How do you feel towards **that**?

Curiosity, compassion, calm?

or....



Untangling

How do you feel towards **that**?

For this **new layer**, notice the qualities of body sensations, imagery, what's its deal...



ANTI-FRUSTRATION

tension in shoulders
I don't want to be frustrated!
want to be "good meditator"

FE
col
aw

Untangling

How do you feel towards **that**?



ANTI-FRUSTRATION

tension in shoulders

I don't want to be frustrated!

want to be "good meditator"

Fr

gri

wa

FE

col

aw

Turning towards

OOOF.

YEAH, buddy, I get that!!

**NO
frustration!
ZEN!!!**

Turning towards

The move that is most valuable here, is the feeling of really *getting* a part in the way it needs you to get it.

Once that part's message has been delivered and received, there's often a softening that follows, which opens up way more space to work with the underlying parts in a more easeful way that allows things to move and change.

Questions?

then part 2...

Sensing

1. What do you **want**?
2. What do you **need**?
3. How will you **feel** when you get what you need?
4. **Leaning into the feeling**, letting it be as big as it wants, as a sensation in the body.
5. **Noticing any shifts or changes.**

Sensing 1. Ask the part: What do you want?

(This is the part's strategy, and it might be an impulse that not all of you endorses – for example, “I want to smack that guy in the face!”)

Notice what answer you get,
and write this on the card.

ANTI-FRUSTRATION

tension in shoulders

I don't want to be frustrated!

want to be “good meditator”

FE

col

aw

NO
Frustration!
Frustration!!

Sensing 2. Ask the part: What do you need?

(or: What does that get you? Is there anything even deeper or more important, that you get through this strategy?)

- (see eg [this list of needs](#) for examples – it might be something like, “to be heard, and seen”)

Notice what answer you get,
and write this on the card.

ANTI-FRUSTRATION

tension in shoulders

FE I don't want to be frustrated!

gri want to be “good meditator”

FE wa need to be accepted, belong

col

aw

Sensing

3. Ask the part:

How will you feel when you get what you need?

(eg: confident and strong / comfortable & relaxed / alive & warm...)



Notice what answer you get,
and write this on the card.

ANTI-FRUSTRATION

tension in shoulders

F I don't want to be frustrated!

F I want to be "good meditator"

F I need to be accepted, belong

feel deeply okay

F

col

aw

Feeling

4. Lean into the feeling, letting it be as big as it wants, as a sensation in the body.

If you're having trouble with that, try:

- **Is there anything even deeper or more important**, that you get through [feeling strong]?
 - What does that get you? ex: safety
- Treat the objection as its own part, go back through the steps
- See if it's okay to feel it just in this moment

Noticing

5. Notice any shifts or changes in the appearance of the part, in what it wants, in its relationship to you or other parts.

You may want to move cards around to reflect these shifts, or add notes.

For example, maybe you've understood the anti-frustration part, and it has softened back, allowing you to get to know the frustrated part.

ANTI-FRUSTRATION

tense

I do

want

need

feel

FRUSTRATED

grimace, grrr

want fear to GO AWAY

needs COURAGE

will feel STRONG

FEAR

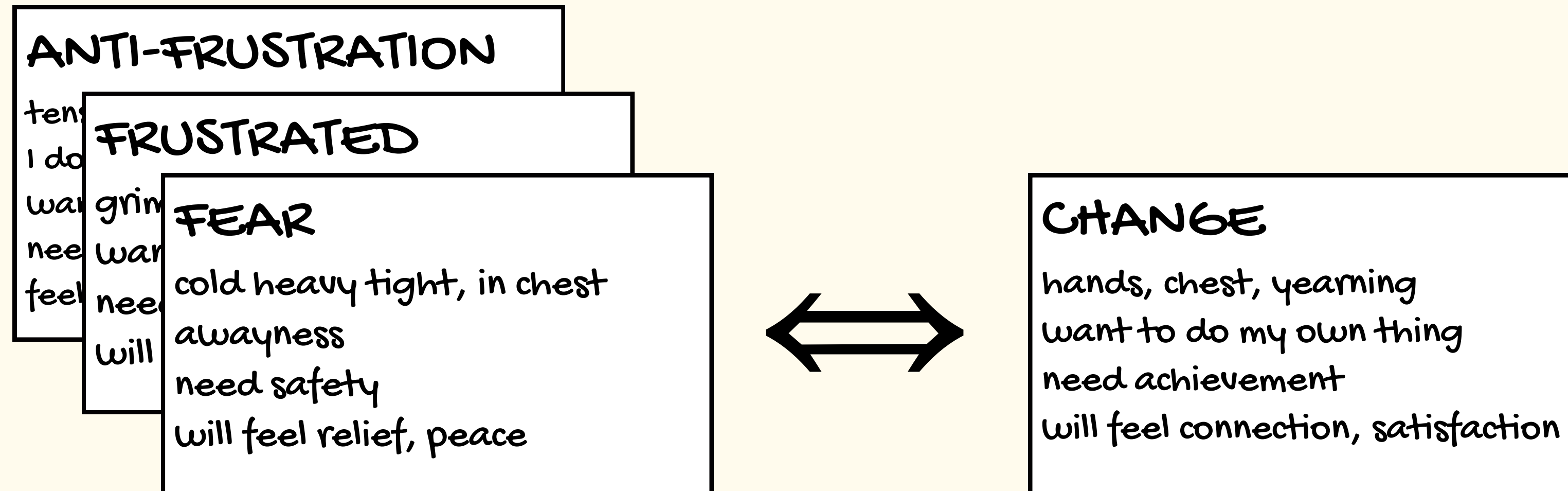
cold heavy tight, in chest
awayness

Noticing

5. Notice any shifts or changes in the appearance of the part, in what it wants, in its relationship to you or other parts.

Maybe once you get the frustrated part, in the way it needs you to get it, there's more space to explore the tension between a part of you that's afraid of changing, and a part of you that really wants something new.

Describe what each of them is wanting and/or feeling, and write a sentence or two about the dynamic that connects them:

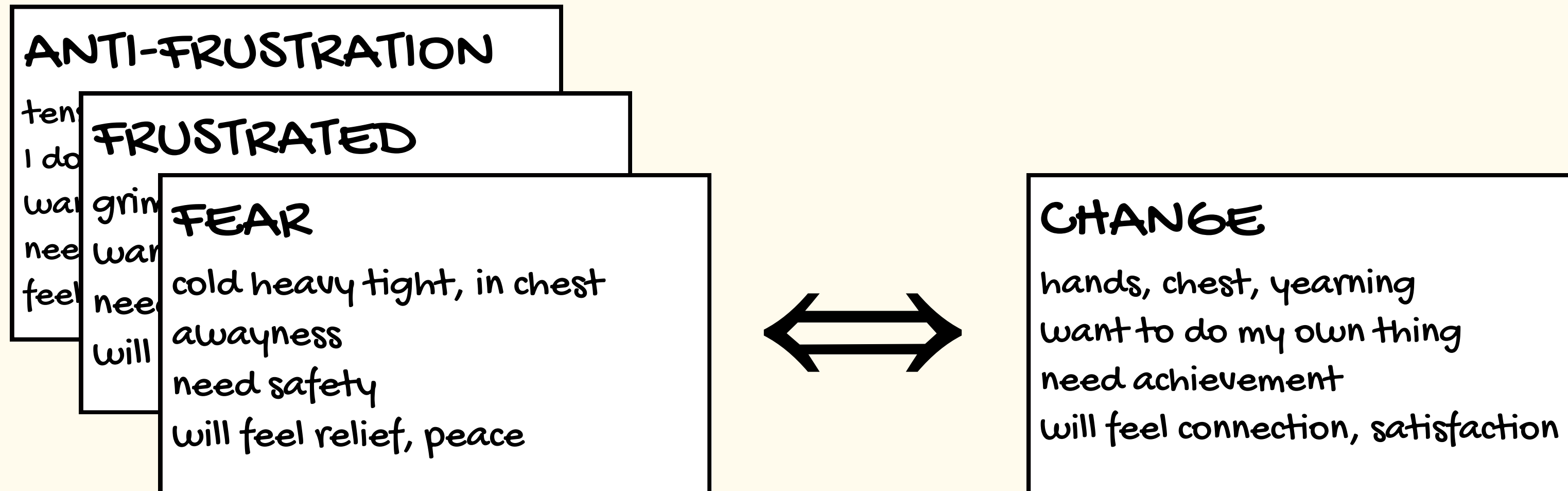


Noticing

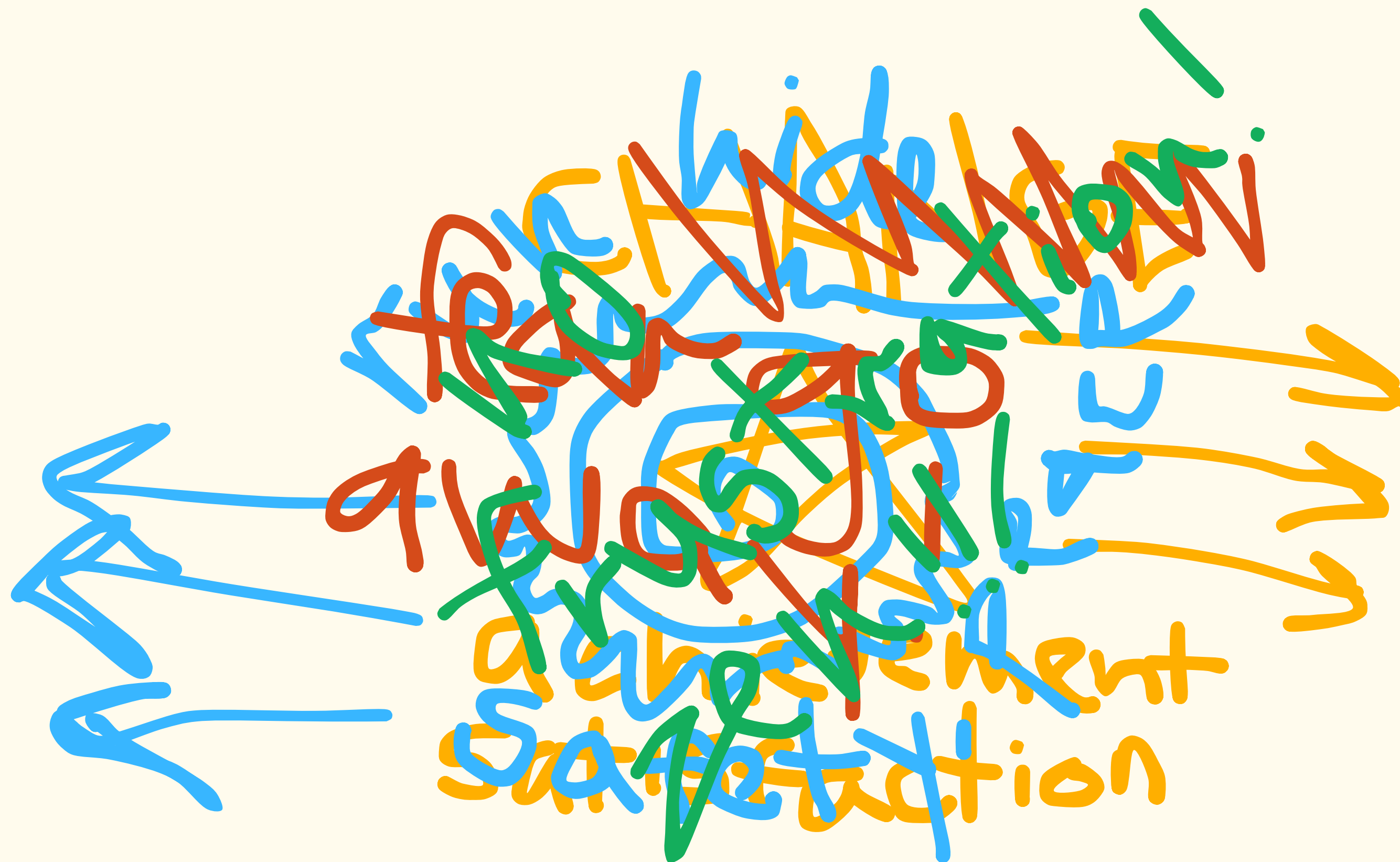
6. Check back in with the initial situation

How're you feeling? Any other parts wanting attention? Has any space opened up? Any new clarity on how you want to approach things, and what's making sense from here?

If needed, repeat steps 1-6 for any other parts that want your attention



It's hard to “just do things” when your wants look like this...



tension in shoulders
I don't want to be frustrated!
want to be "good meditator"
need to be accepted, belong
feel deeply okay

no
frustration!
zen!!!

fear go
away!

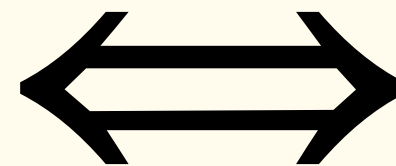
grimace, gmr
want fear to GO AWAY
needs COURAGE
will feel STRONG



**and a lot clearer
like this**



cold heavy tight, in chest
alwayness
need safety
will feel relief, peace



hands, chest, yearning
want to do my own thing
need achievement
will feel connection, satisfaction

no
frustration!
zen!!

ANTI-FRUSTRATION

tension in shoulders
I don't want to be frustrated!
want to be "good meditator"
need to be accepted, belong
feel deeply okay

W
fear go
away!

FRUSTRATED

grimace, gmr
want fear to GO AWAY
needs COURAGE
will feel STRONG

run hide
safety

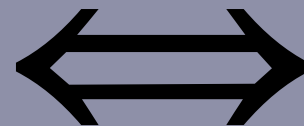
FEAR

cold heavy tight, in chest
alwayness
need safety
will feel relief, peace

CHANGE
achievement
satisfaction

CHANGE

hands, chest, yearning
want to do my own thing
need achievement
will feel connection, satisfaction



Overview

- Identifying: situation, feeling, body sensations, parts
- Asking yourself: How do you feel towards that?

If you feel curious,
calm, compassionate:



If you feel impatient, frustrated,
scared, ashamed, etc: turn towards
that feeling as a part in its own right



- Asking the part:
 - What do you **want**?
 - What do you **need**?
 - How will you **feel** when you get what you need?
- Leaning into the feeling as a sensation in the body, and noticing any shifts or changes.

Troubleshooting

Some common challenges in self-facilitating parts work include:

- Nothing coming up / unsure how to discern felt sense
- Too much coming up / feel overwhelmed, need grounding
- Cognitive overload / trouble switching – tough to keep track of many parts and layers while also stepping into the felt perspectives of different parts

Extra slides

Parts work context

When you feel conflicted about something, this can be understood as an **interaction between “parts” of yourself.**

- Sometimes people interact with “parts” as fleeting interfaces for sensations, feelings, internal subroutines and beliefs, which arise temporarily and then merge back into the rest of our experience.
- Sometimes people interact with “parts” as richly personified, recurring internal characters.
- Parts may be experienced as thoughts, feelings, sensations, imagery, memories, impulses, internal narration, or other ways.

Parts work context

Any pattern of thought, feeling or behavior is coming from a part with some **positive intent** for your wellbeing.

- Even if the pattern is frustrating or upsetting to you
- Even if its current strategy is not achieving that intent, or has costly side-effects, or if the pattern is itself a purposeless side-effect of some other strategy.
- This part is trying to achieve some desirable outcome, or prevent some feared outcome.

Parts work context

This strategy ***makes sense*** to some part of you, **based on its understanding of the world.**

- This part learned something about how the world works, in a way that made a deep emotional impression at some point in the past. This strategy makes sense based on that understanding.

Parts work context

That worldview is likely missing crucial elements that you've learned in the time since that belief was formed.

- That's why the strategy isn't working well to achieve that positive intent.

Parts work context

This path to resolving internal conflicts involves:

- becoming **familiar** with the parts involved,
- **understanding** their view of the world, and
- **connecting with the emotions** that are present, while remaining grounded.

Take a moment to consider: what grounding methods work well for you? For example:

- Naming things you can see, touch, hear, smell, taste
- Connecting with your breath and making the exhale just slightly longer than the inhale
- Moving your body, starting with very tiny movements or big movements
- If you find that your body sensations can be distressing or overwhelming, there's a "Pendulation" exercise that can be a good fit

Parts work context

Internal alignment happens through **holding *both* views of the world** at the same time, in a way that invites parts of you to update to a fuller sense of your present situation.

- This often involves going back and forth between two views, feeling the emotional truth of each—especially if it's surprising!

Questions & Reflections

link to slides

@SarahAMcManus



Also: Event in SF

Wed Apr 22

6-9pm